Plane Fuel Costs More Than Ever, and Holiday Flights Cost More Too

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Are you flying somewhere for the holidays? Get ready: tickets may cost a lot more this year.

The main reason is **jet fuel**, the special fuel airplanes burn. It is one of the biggest costs for airlines. On Thursday, the average price of **jet fuel** in the United States reached $4.90 a gallon, according to the tracking firm Argus. That is the highest one-day average Argus has ever recorded, and more than double the price a year ago.

Airlines are passing part of the cost to passengers. **Airfares** are at a 10-year high, said Hayley Berg, the lead **economist** at Hopper, a travel tech company. Thanksgiving tickets cost about 30% more than last year, and Christmas tickets are up more than 20%.

Still, people keep booking. Delta Air Lines CEO Ed Bastian said travelers still see tickets as fairly **affordable**. Chris Sununu, head of the **trade group** Airlines for America, said airlines are paying most of the extra fuel cost themselves, but some must be passed on to customers.

Families are coping in different ways. Many booked trips earlier than usual to lock in lower prices. Rachel Stern of Frederick, Maryland, said tickets for her and her kids cost too much, so she will drive to Chicago instead.

Word Treasure

jet fuel -- The special fuel that airplanes burn to fly.

airfares -- The prices people pay for airplane tickets.

economist -- An expert who studies money, prices and how they change.

trade group -- An organization that speaks for a whole group of companies, such as airlines.

affordable -- Cheap enough that most people can pay for it.

Background you need

Airplanes burn a special fuel called jet fuel, and it is one of the biggest costs for airlines.

When jet fuel gets more expensive, airlines often pass part of that extra cost on to the people buying tickets.

That is why flights can cost more at busy travel times like Thanksgiving and Christmas, when many families fly to visit each other.

Break it down

WHO: Airlines, holiday travelers and families planning trips
WHAT: Jet fuel prices reached a record high, and holiday airfares climbed to a 10-year high
WHERE: In the United States, including one Maryland family's planned trip to Chicago
WHY: Jet fuel is one of the biggest costs for airlines and its price more than doubled in a year, so airlines pass part of the cost on to passengers

Why it matters

If your family flies to visit relatives for the holidays, higher ticket prices could change how -- or whether -- you make the trip.

Test what you remember

1. What price did jet fuel reach on Thursday?

(A) $4.90 a gallon
(B) $9.40 a gallon
(C) $2.40 a gallon
(D) $1.90 a gallon

2. How do this year's airfares compare with past years?

(A) They dropped by half
(B) They have not changed at all
(C) They are the cheapest ever recorded
(D) They are at a 10-year high

3. About how much more do Thanksgiving tickets cost than last year?

(A) About 5% more
(B) About 10% more
(C) About 30% more
(D) About 90% more

4. Who said travelers still see tickets as fairly affordable?

(A) Rachel Stern, a mom from Maryland
(B) Ed Bastian, the Delta Air Lines CEO
(C) Hayley Berg, an economist at Hopper
(D) Chris Sununu, head of a trade group

5. What did many families do to cope with the high prices?

(A) They bought bigger suitcases
(B) They booked trips earlier than usual to lock in lower prices
(C) They waited for prices to go up
(D) They decided to stop traveling

6. What will Rachel Stern do instead of flying to Chicago?

(A) Stay home for the holidays
(B) Take a train
(C) Fly on a different holiday
(D) Drive to Chicago

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: D 3: C 4: B 5: B 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Ed Bastian, Delta Air Lines CEO: He said travelers still see tickets as fairly affordable, and people keep booking flights.

2. Chris Sununu, head of the trade group Airlines for America: He said airlines are paying most of the extra fuel cost themselves, but some of it must be passed on to customers.

3. Rachel Stern, a traveler from Frederick, Maryland: She said tickets for her and her kids cost too much, so she will drive to Chicago instead of flying.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):